

marketing. Inox, says, "Last year, *Antaheen* by Aniruddha 'Tony' Roy Chowdhury was a landmark film. Content has become king again." Names are changing too; many sound distinctly "un-Bengali" now. Filmmaker Subrata Sen, the man who launched Konkona Sen Sharma in *Ek Je Acchey Konnya* in 2001, says, "Bengali films have been timelessly called stuff like *Nyaya-Annaye* and *Vichar-Avichar*. It had almost become an education in antonyms. All this is changing."

Birsa Dasgupta, 30-year-old grandson of filmmaker Harisadhan Dasgupta, would agree. His film, *033*, made on a budget of Rs 1.5 crore, is being jointly produced by NDTV Imagine, its first film production, and the Moxie Group. Says Dasgupta, "*033* is Kolkata's telephone code. In this film, it is also the name of a rock band and the film explores music tradition and how connections are made and broken through music." Swastika

like Rituparno Ghosh's *Chokher Bali* and *Raincoat*. Chakrabarty, 34, started his career with TV five years ago. He got noticed with two top reality shows, *Mirakkel Akkel* and *Dance Bangla* and telefilms *Teesta*, *Ek Chhut* and *Naba Basanto* between 2005 and 2006. His first film *Chirodini Tumi Je Amar* in 2007 created history, grossing 15 times its budget of Rs 80 lakh. His next two films, the Rs 2-crore *Challenge* fetched 10 times that amount and *Prem Amar*, a Rs 1.5-crore film, fetched 20 times the money invested. Coming up is *Le*

Kalyan Roy, in a cameo appearance. He is set to become producer this year and he has chosen Aveek Mukherjee, 42, cinematographer of *Bunty Aur Babli*, as his director for *Ekta Tarar Khoje*, which will see the return of Shayan Munshi and Prosenjit Chatterjee's wife, Arpita, to the big screen. "This film had 15 main characters playing an equal, pivotal role. Shabana Azmi said she thought it was at least a Rs 10-crore film because its look had fascinated her," says Roy Chowdhury.

Even Prosenjit, 50, has put his



(LEFT) FIRDAUS, RITUPARNA SENGUPTA AND PRIYANSHU CHATTERJEE IN JEET DUTTA'S *POTADAR KIRTI*; SHARMILA TAGORE AND APARNA SEN ARE SEEN TOGETHER IN TONY'S *ANTAHEEN*



The film industry is changing its look to reflect the young men and women of today. They are aggressive and smart. It is a bonus that these films are making money as well.

ANIRUDDHA ROY CHOWDHURY, Director of *Antaheen*

Mukherjee, 30, who plays the lead, has signed her eighth film in a matter of a few months, making her perhaps the first Tollywood heroine to do so.

The Midas touch is now in the hands of a few, the new movers and shakers of Tollywood such as actor Dev, director Raj Chakrabarty, composer Jeet Ganguly and the giant, Venkatesh Films (VF). Run by Shrikant Mohta and Mahendra Soni, VF has produced national award-winning films

*Chhakka*. "My theme and story are very unconventional. I am using cricket to counter politics," he says.

One of the most significant movies made last year which set the mainstream ball rolling towards meaningful cinema was the Rs 1.5-crore *Antaheen*. It raked in profits that were twice the investment. In *Antaheen*, Roy Chowdhury, 44, brought Sharmila Tagore and Aparna Sen to work with Sen's husband,

customary heroics on the backburner and will be seen in two films, *Clerk* (for the first time in Bengal, the posters of the film show the hero in a bathtub) and *Lalan*, a film based on the legendary folk singer. Kaushik Ganguly is ready with his film, *Arekti Premier Golpo*, on gay love made on a budget of Rs 1.5 crore. Bengali films seem to be well out of their musty closet but where they go from here is a story in the making. ■